WEIGHT 17

Topiramate

Anti-seizure drug (a sulfamate-substituted sugar); for weight, approved only combined with phentermine



CLASS
Anti-seizure drug

STUDIED FOR
Epilepsy, migraine, weight

HUMAN EVIDENCE
Large trials; FDA approved

US STATUS
FDA approved (Topamax); weight: Qsymia

STUDIED FOR

Seizures	Migraine prevention	Body weight
HUMAN	HUMAN	HUMAN

Weight use alone is off-label. For weight, FDA approved topiramate only combined with phentermine, as Qsymia (2012).

HOW IT WORKS IN THE BODY

Topiramate → Sodium channels → GABA up, glutamate → Seizure control

- **Label:** the exact action in epilepsy and migraine is unknown
- **Lab studies:** blocks some sodium channels and a type of glutamate receptor
- **Lab studies:** raises GABA activity; inhibits carbonic anhydrase
- **Weight loss** is a common side effect; the label does not explain how

EVIDENCE & WHAT'S KNOWN

EVIDENCE

FDA APPROVED
LEVEL 5 OF 5

- Alone for weight: RCTs of 385 and 1,289 adults
- Qsymia: two 1-year trials, 3,754 adults
- Approved for epilepsy since 1996

NOT YET ESTABLISHED

- Fertility effects in people

QUICK PRACTICAL INFO

HALF-LIFE
About 21 hours (Topamax label)

ROUTES STUDIED
By mouth (tablets, sprinkle capsules)

PHARMACOKINETICS
Peak about 2 hours; mostly unchanged in urine (about 70%)

SOLD AS
Prescription (Topamax tablets, sprinkle capsules); Qsymia

MONITORED IN TRIALS
Serum bicarbonate; monthly pregnancy tests (Qsymia)

SPORT (WADA)
Not on the 2026 list

REGULATORY

FDA	Approved: Topamax 1996; weight only via Qsymia
FDA	Qsymia REMS for birth-defect risk
EMA	Pregnancy prevention programme since 2023
WADA	Not prohibited

REFERENCES

1. FDA, Topamax prescribing information, Oct 2026
2. FDA, Qsymia prescribing information, Apr 2026
3. Wilding et al., topiramate for weight, Int J Obes, Nov 2004

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